

# Epistemic Trespass

**W**E HAVE SEEN examples throughout this book that experts are not always right even in their own area of expertise. When they venture outside their field into other areas, the risks of being wrong increase—this is called “epistemic trespass.”

Nathan Ballantyne is an associate professor of philosophy, cognition, and culture at Arizona State University. He has observed that experts can drift over “highly visible boundary lines and into domains where they lack the relevant evidence or skills... but they keep talking nonetheless.”<sup>377</sup>

Professionals typically possess a hard-won competency that allows them to make good judgments within their area of expertise. All of us should be more skeptical of those who “move into another field where they lack competence and pass judgment anyway.”<sup>378</sup> Epistemic trespassers have proved themselves to be unreliable judges in fields where they are outsiders.

One of my favorite examples of this shows up (ironically) in the repeated attempts to debunk Dunning-Kruger, typically by mathematicians arguing the effects are statistically insignificant or just random noise. Those arguments have been contradicted by larger studies that repeatedly confirmed the original, underlying research.<sup>379</sup>

Smart people can suffer from *deformation professionnelle* (“occupational deformity”)—a DKE-related tendency to view the world through the lens of one’s own profession.<sup>380</sup> It’s not surprising that a mathematician looks at a psychological phenomenon and sees only the statistics. Performing statistical analysis on psychology research while unaware of decades of underlying research in psychology sounds a lot like the Dunning-Kruger effect at work.

It makes me wonder if Dunning-Kruger explains *everything*—or at least